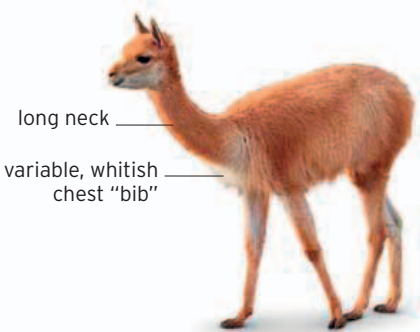


Vicuña

Vicugna vicugna



A small, slender relative of the llama and the alpaca, the vicuña is well adapted to life in the high Andes. It lives in small family groups in arid meadows above 11,500 ft (3,500 m) and sometimes as high as 18,850 ft (5,750 m), but always below the snow line. In this environment, days are frequently sunny and warm, so tough thickets of grass can grow. At night, the thin air chills rapidly and temperatures plunge below freezing. The vicuña has a thick fleece of fine-layered hairs, which traps warm air around its body and keeps the cold out.

Unique teeth

The vicuña has unique teeth for a hoofed mammal. The front teeth (incisors) in its lower jaw grow constantly, like those of a rodent, and have enamel only on the front. The incisors are kept sharp by constant contact

with the hard dental pad in the upper jaw as the vicuña relentlessly uses its molars to chew the tough grass. Vulnerable to attack on open grassland, vicuñas are always on the lookout for predators, such as foxes. They have excellent hearing and vision and when a predator is spotted, they give a warning whistle.

Families, led by a single male, consist of about five females and their young. The groups stay small, with only about 10 members, because the chief male drives away the young at the age of 10 months. Young vicuñas live alone or form single-sex herds until they start their own families at about the age of two. Unusually, vicuñas have separate feeding and sleeping territories, which are mostly marked out with dung. Vicuñas need to drink water every day so their feeding territory has to have a source of fresh water.

↔ 5 ft (1.5 m)

🏋️ 88–120 lb (40–55 kg)

⊗ Locally common

🌿 Grass

W. South America

